WILL HYDRAA LOSE ITS HEAD?

A crack anti-encroachment unit gets a rap from the court, but Revanth backs his 'demolition man'

By **Prasad Nichenametla**



TAKING AN AXE Hydraa demolition drive in Ilapur, Sangareddy district, Apr. 12

Takeaways

- **Hydraa, Hyderabad's encroachment buster, gets a judicial rap**
- **Unit a 'law unto itself', its chief Ranganath 'a habitual offender', says HC**
- **Ranganath says Hydraa has restored six lakes; Revanth backs the body**

A FEAT COMPARABLE TO THE ANNEXATION OF PRINCELY STATES into the Indian Union? That's the grandiose picture commissioner A.V. Ranganath likes to draw. What occasions this claim? The agency that runs under his watch, Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency (Hydraa), says it has reclaimed 3,325 acres of government land and natural resources like lakes from encroachers in the Telangana capital area in the two years since its formation. Together, that vast acreage is said to be the worth a whopping Rs 1.5 lakh crore. In a booming city, where state auctions are fetching upwards of Rs 200 crore an acre in prime localities, the figure seems credible. Yet, what Hydraa has earned from the courts is a baleful moniker: "a law unto itself."

The numbers speak of breathless and, well, hydra-headed work: those 3,325 acres include 2,665 acres of trespassed government land, 454 acres marked as lakes and ponds, 90 acres of park area, 62 acres of roads and footpaths, as well as over 25 acres of *nullahs* (drains). For such an exploit, Ranganath, a 2006 batch IPS officer promoted from the state services, would have felt he merited a top medal or state honour. Instead, what came his way are 63 contempt of court notices—and a different kind of closure. A few days after Hydraa completed two years, the Telangana High Court on July 27 directed the state chief secretary to remove Ranganath from his post forthwith and replace him with another officer—a directive that was suspended by a division bench on September 1.

The single-judge order had come after a real estate developer filed a petition charging the IPS officer with repeated contempt of court. The firm alleged that Hydraa's interference in their property at Lothukunta, Secunderabad, was 'illegal' since the agency's actions were in defiance of the relief the court had granted earlier.

Taking serious note of three contempt of court petitions in a single matter, the HC observed the Hydraa commissioner had become "a law unto himself". The court even said it could order the deployment of armed forces to